



▲ DEAD ZONES

Many rivers are so contaminated with toxins that they have created underwater dead zones where they drain into the sea. One of the biggest lies off the Mississippi Delta in the Gulf of Mexico. Created by the poisoned sediments, seen swirling into the sea in this aerial view, the dead zone covers 8,500 sq miles (22,000 sq km).

COASTAL DESTRUCTION ►

Tourist developments have caused massive destruction of coastal habitats, especially in the tropics. Coastal mangroves have been swept away, exposing coasts to tropical storms. Soil carried off deforested shores by heavy rain also pollutes the sea, smothering nearby coral reefs and seagrass beds.



◀ WRECKED REEFS

Many tropical coral reefs like this one have been damaged by divers and the anchors of dive boats and leisure craft. They also suffer from pollution released by badly planned coastal developments. In Indonesia, valuable reef fish are illegally stunned with cyanide, a deadly poison, so they can be collected for the pet trade—even though the poison soon kills them.